I put my wall up. I was prickly. The tension between us was obvious. Yet, on reflection, I realized that such sullen silence was wrong. As I said to Alice when I returned home, ‘He’s a bloke I batted with for England, a bloke I called Skipper. We can’t let things get to this.’

Life isn’t lived in a straight line. Everyone goes through blips, and I would go through one more, talking starkly and occasionally darkly about my future as England captain with Paul Farbrace before that summer’s Ashes series. That’s the nature of leadership. You teeter between necessary optimism and understandable pessimism.

Captaincy is rarely hunky dory. It just isn’t like that. I had been taking the job home more often than I should. Though I’m usually pretty good at leaving cricket at the door, it is impossible, no matter what anyone says, to do that consistently. It is always there, at the back of your mind. You need to establish a balance before you tip yourself over the edge.

After speaking to Alice, I took the initiative, picked up the phone to Vaughan, and got a few things off my chest. I reasoned that whatever happened, things could not go any worse than they had done over the previous year or so. We arranged lunch, and he talked animatedly, and insightfully, about the Australians, and the nature of the challenge that awaited.

I’d had a similar clear-the-air discussion with Shane Warne the previous year, telling him I found his criticism highly unfair. We had kept in touch, and the world hadn’t fallen in. That, and the appointment of Farbrace as interim coach for the two-Test series against New Zealand, helped me move from being a closed book to a more receptive personality.

The mood was helped by the tenor of the opposition. The Kiwis, under Brendon McCullum, were a refreshingly open team. They reminded us it was possible to play Test cricket with spirit, and without a snarl. They were at ease. They had found themselves as a side. Losing didn’t hurt them any less, but they had more of a smile on their faces. They didn’t take themselves seriously.

They knew what they were meant to be. They had an underdog’s mentality and chased the ball to the boundary as if their lives depended on it until the moment it hit the rope. As McCullum explained over a beer, ‘We can’t afford not to. We’re not good enough to go, “Oh, well, someone else will just score those four runs …”’